Cynefin® Sense-Making

Sort situations by how predictable they are, then choose an approach that fits: analyse, experiment, act or follow the rule.

Lead the Organisation · Inspired by the Cynefin® Framework (Dave Snowden) · Sense-Making · Choose Your Approach

TOPIC _____

DATE _____

1 Complex

PROBE · SENSE · RESPOND

Cause and effect only make sense afterwards.
Run safe-to-fail experiments; amplify what works.

`Practice: emergent`

Things we can only learn by trying

2 Complicated

SENSE · ANALYSE · RESPOND

Cause and effect can be found with analysis or expertise. Ask the experts and weigh options.

`Practice: good practice (more than one right answer)`

Things experts can work out

3 Chaotic

ACT · SENSE · RESPOND

No visible cause and effect. Act first to stabilise, then move the situation to complex.

`Practice: novel`

Crises needing action now

4 Clear

SENSE · CATEGORISE · RESPOND

Cause and effect are obvious to everyone.
Follow the agreed practice, but watch for complacency.

`Practice: best practice · beware the cliff into chaos`

Things with a known right answer

5 Confused? Split It Up

THE CENTRE

When you can't tell which domain you're in, you're in confusion. People fall back on the approach they like best. Break the situation into parts and place each part in a domain.

Part 1: _____

Part 2: _____

Part 3: _____

Part 4: _____

6 Our Approach

FOR THE SITUATION WE CHOSE

Situation: _____

Main domain: _____

So we will: _____

Safe-to-fail experiments: _____

Signs it's working: _____

Signs to stop: _____

Amplify or dampen by: _____

Revisit on: _____

"Are we treating a complex problem as if it were only complicated?"

"What's the smallest safe-to-fail experiment we could run?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/better-delivery-toolkit

Cynefin® is a registered trademark of Cognitive Edge Pte Ltd · Lead the Organisation